

Regular Meeting
May 2, 2016
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:00 p.m. Those present were Ms. Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the minutes of April 11, 2016 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to suspend the rules to take papers out of order:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Accept Gift from Century Bank to Purchase a Teacher Developed Elementary School Guide to the History of Medford

Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell said that it was with great pleasure that she present the book written by Michael Coates, 3rd grade teacher, entitled *Our Medford: An Elementary Guide to the History of Medford*. He will be piloting the book in all third grade classrooms at the Brooks this year and with your approval all third grades will use this as part of their social studies curriculum next year. Mr. Coates researched his facts and worked with the Medford Historical Society's Educational Outreach coordinator, Allison Andrews to ensure his book for accuracy. In April, Mr. Coates contacted Century Bank to ask if they would consider helping with the cost of printing this book.

As usual President and CEO of Century Bank Barry Sloane stepped up and not only agreed to assist us this year but in addition, offered to help with printing costs for next year. Next year all of our third graders will read this book by Mr. Coates. Mr. Sloane was presented with a plaque of appreciation from the school department and the committee.

Discussion:

Members thanked Mr. Sloane and congratulated Mr. Coates. Mr. Sloane said that Medford is our home and they will do anything to help Medford education.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to accept the gift:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

The book can be purchased from the Historical Society for \$20.

Report on Scholastic Medal Winner

Director of Humanities Dr. Nicole Chiesa presented the report. Dr. Chiesa stated that the English Language Arts department is very pleased to announce that Hannah Rogers, a freshman has earned a Silver Medal in the National Scholastic Writing Awards for her piece entitled *James*. This represents the first time a student from Medford has become a National Medalist in the Scholastic Art & Writing Awards. Winners at the national level have the opportunity to earn scholarships and have their works published. Hannah was presented with an award certificate from the School Committee.

Discussion:

Members congratulated Hannah and her teacher Jodi Liu.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Reports on Social Studies Special Events

Dr. Nicole Chiesa began by saying that she is pleased to announce that on March 5 three Medford High School students and one Andrews Middle School student took part in the Greater Boston's District's National History Day competition. Medford students competed alongside 200 students from the region. Dr. Nelson said that in early June the Social Studies department will be hosting a National History Day Fair and the entries will be displayed there. The students were honored with certificates from the School Committee.

Dr. Chiesa continued with the Model United Nations. She said that on March 4th fifteen Medford High School students and ten middle school students participated in the invitational Model United Nations Conference held at Northeastern University. Model

United Nations is an opportunity for students to think critically about global issues, engage in presentation and writing skills and connect with others to share global interests. Although the high school has participated in past years, this year marks the first year that our middle schools had competed. The high school students will return to Northeastern University on May 13th to the Regional conference. Award certificates were presented to the students.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion to revert back to the regular order of business:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Committee of Whole Minutes April 25, 2016

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to waive the reading of the minutes

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Curriculum Sub-Committee Minutes April 27, 2016

Sub-Committee Chairperson Paulette Van der Kloot read the minutes. Meeting was called to order by Chairperson Paulette Van der Kloot at 7:05 p.m. in the Superintendent's Conference Room at Medford High School.

All rose to salute the Flag.

Sub-committee members present included Chairperson Van der Kloot and Mr. Robert Skerry. Sub-committee member Mea Mustone joined the meeting at 7:35 p.m. School committee member Erin DiBenedetto joined the meeting at 7:25 p.m.

Also in attendance were Superintendent Belson, Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson, Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell and Director of Curriculum Bernadette Ricciardelli.

There were five parents in attendance as follows:

- Kate Carson
- Michelle Ciccolo
- Jennifer Lewis
- Cheryl Rodriguez
- Ellery Klein

The Superintendent identified three agenda items:

- PARCC "opt out" situation
- Parent concerns regarding homework policy and practice
- State Accountability System and Medford Performance

Superintendent explained the role and rules governing sub-committee meetings. Superintendent asked Deputy Superintendent to explain the State/DESE guidance on “opt-Out” of the state tests.

Deputy Superintendent Nelson provided a handout that identified the state’s position. State Law MGL C69 requires that “all students who are educated with Massachusetts public funds participate in a statewide student assessment program.”

It was explained that the state urged us to encourage participation but there would be no penalty for any student/parent who declined. However, it is unclear what the impact would be on the school/school district’s rating if students were not counted as test takers. DESE has been very strict about participation over the years.

While the committee voiced several concerns about the testing system it was acknowledged that this is a difficult predicament. The number of students opting out at this time is very small.

The meeting then moved on to hear parental concerns about the homework policy and practice.

Jen Lewis made an initial presentation (see attached). She raised issues of quantity, quality and variations among teachers. There was particular concern regarding homework in the early grades. Also there was concern about some teachers using homework as a punishment. This might include the loss of recess time.

Parent Kate Carson (a teacher herself) talked about the stress that homework places on young children and families. She cited the thinking of Tufts Professor Martha Potts.

Parent Michelle Ciccolo felt the nightly homework was too much.

Parent Ellery Klein said that studies show that homework for early learners is not effective.

Parent Cheryl Rodriguez was pro homework and felt it played a valuable role.

Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell talked about the new k-2 program initiative.

Superintendent Belson spoke on the need to be developmentally appropriate and that using homework as a punishment is not acceptable. He emphasized that homework well done can be important but that it is not to be a “make work” activity.

Chairperson Van der Kloot commented that she experienced good homework with her children years ago which engaged the family and the student.

The Committee will study the parent proposal and report back. Meanwhile the administrators will reinforce best practices with our teaching faculty.

The meeting then moved to the topic of the State Accountability System and the Medford performance 2015. There was particular emphasis on the Roberts School.

Superintendent Belson made the following introductory statement:

As we begin our review of the accountability status we should initially focus on the big picture.

The Medford Public Schools has eight schools that are eligible for accountability ratings by DESE. Only one school has been designated as a Level 3 school. That designation was one point below the Level 2 threshold.

Medford High School and Medford Vocation are designated as Level 1 schools.

Additionally, both are fully accredited by NEASC. The ratings for our two high school programs are better than many other schools across the Commonwealth.

Please note a few examples:

Waltham High – Level 3

Woburn High – Level 3
Quincy High – Level 2
Peabody High – Level 3
Malden High – Level 3

Our two middle schools and three elementary schools are rated as Level 2 which is good when matched with demographically comparable schools in the Commonwealth.

Please note a few examples:

Reading Elementary – Level 3
Somerville Elementary – Level 3
Waltham Elementary – Level 3
Quincy Elementary – Level 3
Framingham Elementary – Level 3

As you will see the State does not meet its own accountability targets.

The State Accountability System is scheduled for a full review in light of the new Federal ESSA law that de-emphasizes test scores as monolithic determinants of school quality. Every school system and each individual school can improve. We are in the business of improvement. Tonight you will not only learn about the issues of the rating system, but you will also learn about the interventions that we have put in place and the additional steps we will take to improve.

Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson made several points about the accountability system and Medford's performance

- She referenced an earlier report on the District and School 2015 Accountability Report.
- The statewide results showed that the state did not meet any of its own targets
- The Roberts report showed improvement in several categories
- Math was more problematic than ELA
- The state changed the threshold for group reporting to 25 which was lower than the past.
- The state's method of grouping schools by school configuration means that the k-5 organization represented 20% of the states elementary schools and left out many urban areas that scored lower than Medford.
- Director of Curriculum Bernadette Ricciardelli joined Deputy Superintendent Nelson to discuss the application of the equipercentile method for correlating MCAS and PARCC scores (see attached). The state clearly "cautioned against making consequential decisions based upon a single test score, a single two year comparison or a single analysis particularly when estimated scores are being used"

There was discussion on the population distribution among the schools. The Superintendent pointed out that the Roberts had a substantial population of ELL newcomers. However, it would be difficult to move them to other schools because of staffing concentrations. Mr. Skerry asked the Superintendent to look into increased space possibilities if it would help the situation. Assistant Superintendent Caldwell spoke on our current and planned interventions.

Current and Past Activities:

- Math support grades 3, 4 and 5

- Directors working with teachers to disaggregate data

ELL

- Addition of two staff members for growing ELL populations
- Addition of two paraprofessionals, one who is a retired sped teacher and specializes in math
- As you know, we have a transient population. Just this week many families are registering for school. Many of these children are non-English speakers who will be required to take PARCC.

Moving Forward

- Hiring of two math coaches for all elementary schools for grade levels 2,3 and 4
- Continue to work with DSAC, ask for professional development opportunities
- Envision going into year 3, hoped to see more positive results
- Intensify classroom review
- Grade level meetings
- Math nights

The discussion turned to the value of coaching. Ms. DiBenedetto had concerns about whether the coaches would be considered teacher evaluators. The answer was no. Ms. Mustone commented that coaching was not evaluative. Ms. Van der Kloot referred to coaches as modeling best practices. The general finding was that the state DSAC was not providing real assistance. DSAC was short on answers. We will continue to work with them.

The subcommittee concluded that we have challenges ahead but there are several concrete measures in place.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry the meeting was adjourned at 9:12 p.m.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Pre Budget Report: English

Director of Humanites Dr. Nicole Chiesa presented the report. Dr. Chiesa reported that the English Language Arts department is dedicated to supporting all teachers in the district who teach this core academic subject. The ELA curriculum is aligned to the *2011 Massachusetts English Language Arts Curriculum Framework* that is based on the Common Core State Standards. Dr. Chiesa continued with an explanation of the use of funding for 2015-2016 and listed the many accomplishments of the school year. She reviewed her budget request for 2016-2017.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked why we need to increase the supplies in the elementary schools, is it due to an increase in students? Superintendent Belson said that is probably just a shift in enrollments; the numbers remain consistent. Ms. DiBenedetto asked Dr. Chiesa what her top request is. She answered that along with the *Journey* supplies an additional high school teacher.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Pre Budget Report: Social Studies

Dr. Chiesa continued with the social studies department. She reported that the social studies department is committed to providing all students with the academic and problem-solving skills essential for personal development, responsible citizenship and lifelong learning.

Dr. Chiesa continued with an explanation of the use of funding for 2015-2016 and listed the many accomplishments of the school year. She reviewed her budget request for 2016-2017.

Discussion:

Ms. Mustone asked if the addition of Chromebooks is enough? Dr. Chiesa answered that they are looking at purchasing more but that will be in her instructional supplies line.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Pre Budget: Health Services

Supervisor Toni Vento presented the report. She stated that the complexity of school nursing has expanded profoundly in the last 20 years. As recently as 20 years ago, there were few students with chronic health illnesses such as diabetes, epilepsy, asthma, complex cardiac disease, or cancer in our school populations. Because of advances in pediatric medicine, students with these illnesses live and eventually attend school. New mandates from the Department of Public Health for student screenings also expand the responsibilities of the school nurse. Ms. Vento continued with the use of funding for school year 2015-2016. She is asking to increase the nursing staff by 2 full time positions. Additional funds will be needed to support the contractual agreements for nurse professional development and professional liability should the 2 FTE positions be received.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto commended Ms. Vento on the wonderful work of her nursing staff especially with the recent training and implementation of NARCAN. She asked about the communication efforts for the screenings in January. Ms. Vento said that a booklet is being prepared for parents/guardians and when it is complete it will be sent to the committee for approval. Ms. DiBenedetto asked what her priority is in this budget. Ms. Vento said increased nursing staff for the Curtis Tufts. Ms. Mustone questioned the cost of the Epipens. Ms. Van der Kloot asked if the LPN at the Brooks is in the budget for next year.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Recommendation to Reject School Participation in School Choice School year 2016-2017
Superintendent Belson stated that under current school law, a school district is assumed to be accepting school choice students for SY 2016-2017, unless the School Committee votes to the contrary. Consequently, I must report an official vote of the Medford School Committee to the Department of Education in June 2016. Otherwise, the Medford School Committee will be obligated to participate in the School Choice Program for the upcoming school year. The School Choice program I am referring to is the external version, not the intradistrict program of choice. After careful consideration, it is my recommendation that the Medford School Committee vote not to participate in the School Choice Program for SY 2016-2017. This has been our position since the beginning of the program. If we are to participate, we would have to accept students from other communities in the Commonwealth for baseline tuition, which could be well below the actual cost of the services that may occur. Such acceptances would be on a seat-available basis and could also affect enrollments selectively throughout the district, and as a result, trigger costs which would add to our budgetary burden. Furthermore, the Medford School Committee has continuously expressed a desire to emphasize servicing Medford students, and to concentrate our efforts in that direction. Lastly, by rejecting this provision, we do not compromise our ability to work with students in our special education programs or our Chapter 74 vocational programs, which are beneficial to our overall program and financial position. For all of the above reasons, I am asking the School Committee to take a vote to reject School Choice for the SY 2016-2017, so that I may notify the Department of Education before the deadline.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to reject School Choice for School Year 2016-2017

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Report on Last Day of School

Superintendent Belson reported that the last day of school for SY 2015-2016 will be Tuesday, June 21, 2016. It will be a 12:00 p.m. release for all schools. The completion of school on this date enables us to meet the state required 180 instructional days minimum and the total hourly minimums for each grade level.

Please note the following regarding early release days during the month of June:

Elementary:

Regular Wednesday Early Release

Tuesday, June 21st 12:00 p.m. release

Middle and High School:

Friday June 17th Early Release

Monday June 20th Early Release

Tuesday June 21st Early Release

The schedule will be posted and advertised to the public as a reminder.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve School Committee Meeting Calendar 2016-2017

Superintendent Belson reported that the dates for next year are consistent with previous years with the exception of October which has been adjusted due to the Jewish Holidays.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot would like the meeting scheduled on October 31, 2016 to be rescheduled due to Halloween. Mr. Skerry asked that the meeting scheduled February 13, 2017 be changed to February 27, 2017. Ms. DiBenedetto requested a report on the opening of school before the first scheduled meeting on September 12, 2016.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the calendar as amended be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to suspend rules to take papers out of order:

Vote:

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Negotiations and Legal Matters placed at the end of the calendar.

New Business

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Maria D'Alleva. Mrs. D'Alleva was the grandmother of Andrews Principal Paul D'Alleva.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Jack Jeffers. Mr. Jeffers was a long time resident of Medford and very active in the West Medford community.

A moment of silence was held.

RFP Development for Winter Season “Bubble” Structure on the “field of Dreams”
Superintendent Belson presented the paper. He read the following: Upon approval by the Medford School Committee an RFP will be developed and include the following process in addition to any necessary language required by the Procurement Office and Law Department.

1. The contract must include a parking lot for an additional 100 cars on the non-turf practice field adjacent to the turf fields paid for by the vendor.
2. The contract must include provisions for a field house with adequate indoor bathroom facilities. It should have a heater installed since it is going to be used during the winter months. All costs of installation and maintenance must be borne by the contractor.
3. The programs operated by the vendor must make substantial provisions for discounting participation fees for Medford youth and residents.
4. The hours of operation must be established in such a way as to avoid conflict with Medford programs and avoid late night impact on abutters.
5. The contractor may not operate programs beyond 11:00 p.m. on any evening.
6. All operational costs associated with the rented program must be borne by the company (vendor). This would include but not limited to electrical, heating, snow plowing, cleanup, maintenance, parking, staffing, etc.
7. There should be sufficient insurance coverage borne by the vendor to cover any damage or liability. The city must be held harmless. All employees of the contractor who work onsite must be CORI checked. Appropriate security coverage will be provided by the vendor/contractor during the contractor’s hours of operation.
8. Access to the main school building should be limited to emergencies.
9. Promotion and advertising of the facility’s purpose and use must be reviewed by the city to ensure that there is no misrepresentation.
10. There must be monthly reporting of activity and facility conditions to the city to ensure that any emergent situations are dealt with in a timely and effective manner.
11. The initial contract will be for a term of seven (7) years with the possibility of a three (3) year extension after five years of successful performance. There must be an out clause in the contract for the city if there is a failure to perform or there is a transfer of ownership control.
12. Substantial non-rental time must be available to the Medford athletic, physical education, and community schools for educational and recreational programs and activities. Any subcontract by the contractor to a third party must be approved in advance by the City of Medford.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto said that she had many questions/concerns. She began with #3 and adding 50% for Medford residents. She would like a penalty fee for not abiding by the rules. She would like a snack shack operated by non profit youth groups or high school clubs/teams. She said that #12 needs to be more specific. Mr. Skerry commented that he hopes that they stick to the rules and no food is allowed on site. Ms. Van der Kloot said

she is concerned with #8 and who would have a key. Superintendent Belson said that the high school custodian would be contacted for entrance to building. Ms. Van der Kloot said that there is no provision for snow day usage. Ms. Cugno suggested that #7 say security will be provided at all time. Superintendent Belson replied that the vendor can't be responsible to provide security during off hours. Ms. Mustone asked what is the date to get the RFP out. Mayor Burke answered the sooner the better. Ms. Cugno wants to make sure that the condition of the field is kept up. Ms. DiBenedetto questioned what money is coming in, how maintenance is paid and commented that this field should last 12 – 15 years – we are in year 8 and with this extra wear and tear may not last as long – they should help repair. There are still many questions to be addressed before moving forward. Ms. Van der Kloot commented that she does not want to see a conflict with the Japanese Language School on Saturdays. Ms. Mustone would like specific times in #12. Ms. DiBenedetto requested including during Christmas and February vacation weeks that our youth organizations be able to use the facility or use it as a fun camp. Ms. Van der Kloot said that it would be helpful if the Superintendent would make the changes and send the draft to members before they meet.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to move the RFP to the Buildings and Grounds sub committee meeting on May 9th.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Superintendent Belson presented the edited letter regarding the charter school cap. He said that the only change was that the word “most” was added to one sentence.

On the motion of Ms. Cugno in support of signing and sending letter to legislature:

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 Cugno, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 1 DiBenedetto
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to go into Executive Session at 9:22 p.m. for the discussion of collective bargaining contracts and possible approval of same, grievance settlement – culinary, and update on legal matters.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

The School Committee returned from Executive Session at 9:40 p.m. and took the following votes.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. Cugno voted contract with Medford School Nurses Association (see attached)

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot voted the contract with Medford Educational Secretaries AFSCME Council 93 Local 338 (see attached)

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Cugno voted grievance resolution with Medford Teachers Association on Culinary Arts Shop Coats:

- 4 chef coats will be provided
- laundry service will be provided beginning September 19, 2016 to you provided the uniforms are passes in
- the service company will be hired and in place by September 19, 2016 and at that time we will provide you with the name of the service and any necessary additional information
- the chef coats you have been given previously will serve as your provided coats for SY 2016-2017

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry, seconded by Ms. Cugno the meeting was adjourned at 9:44 p.m.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Respectfully submitted:

Robert E. Skerry Jr.
Secretary

